



USER GUIDE

Detailed instructions for installing, configuring, running, backing up,
and safely exiting enCounter

Version 0.1.0-alpha.1 • MIT License • Alpha / Pre-release

IMPORTANT: This guide describes the v0.1.0-alpha.1 Reviewed v3 source. Alpha features and screen layouts may change in later releases. Export important data before updating to a newer Alpha build.

Screenshots use sample characters and encounter data created only for documentation.

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1. About enCounter

enCounter is a local-first TTRPG encounter and initiative manager. The DM Console manages reusable characters, initiative, hit points, statuses, encounter state, assets, and backups. A separate Player Display can be placed on a second monitor or TV so players see the initiative order without seeing private DM notes or controls.

- Runs locally on the computer; the packaged Windows and Linux versions do not require Python.
- Stores working application data in the browser using IndexedDB.
- Can write additional automatic JSON backups into the enCounter folder.
- Supports Generic TTRPG, Star Wars Saga Edition, D&D 5E, and a four-stat Custom system profile.
- Supports reusable Player, NPC, Enemy, and Creature Library entries.
- Supports a separate Player Display synchronized with the DM Console in the same browser profile.

IMPORTANT: Use one DM Console window at a time. Multiple DM Console windows can write to the same browser database and the most recent save can overwrite earlier changes.

2. Downloading and Installing

2.1 Windows portable release

1. Open the official enCounter GitHub Releases page and download the Windows portable ZIP that matches the version you want to use.
2. If a SHA-256 checksum is published, verify it when practical before running the program.
3. Right-click the ZIP and choose Extract All. Extract the complete folder to a normal writable location such as Documents, Desktop, or a dedicated Games/Tools folder.
4. Open the extracted enCounter folder and double-click enCounter.exe. Keep enCounter.exe, _internal, programs, assets, data, and the documentation files together in the same folder.

CAUTION: Do not place the portable build under Program Files unless you intentionally manage Windows permissions there. enCounter writes backups and imported assets inside its own folder and therefore works best in a normal writable user folder.

NOTE: The Alpha executable may be unsigned. Windows SmartScreen can show an unknown-publisher/reputation warning. Only continue when the file came from the official project release and you trust the download.

2.2 Linux portable release

1. Download the Linux tar.gz from the matching GitHub Release.
2. Extract the complete archive into a writable folder under your home directory.
3. Run the enCounter executable from the extracted folder. Depending on your desktop environment, you may be able to double-click it.
4. If Linux reports that the file is not executable, open a terminal in the folder and run `chmod +x enCounter`, then run `./enCounter`.

IMPORTANT: Do not move only the executable. The portable program depends on the accompanying _internal, programs, assets, and data folders.

3. Starting enCounter and Startup Recovery

When enCounter starts, it launches a local server on 127.0.0.1:5500 and opens the DM Console in your default browser. The server is local to your computer; it is not intended to be reachable from other computers.

3.1 First launch

1. Start enCounter from the extracted portable folder.
2. Wait for the browser to open the DM Console.
3. Confirm the header shows the expected version, for example ALPHA · v0.1.0-alpha.1.
4. Choose your preferred Settings mode before building a permanent Library if you want to expose additional modules such as Abilities, Resources, or a condition track.

3.2 Resume Last Encounter prompt

If enCounter finds a meaningful saved encounter, startup displays a recovery prompt. You can resume the saved encounter or begin a new one. Choosing New Encounter does not delete the permanent Library, assets, presets, settings, or recovery snapshots.

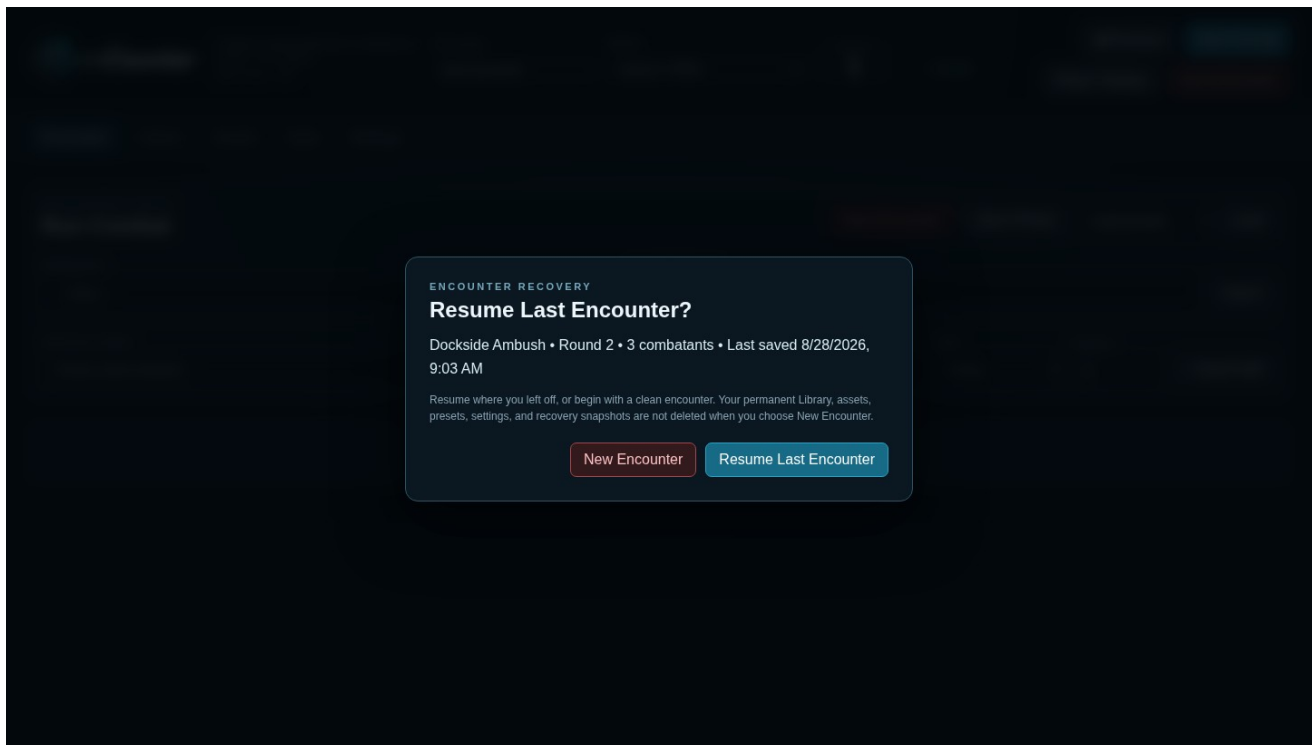


Figure 1 - Startup recovery prompt for a previously saved encounter.

1. Choose Resume Last Encounter when returning to an unfinished session.
2. Choose New Encounter when the previous encounter is no longer needed. enCounter creates a recovery snapshot of the previous meaningful encounter before replacing it.

4. DM Console Overview

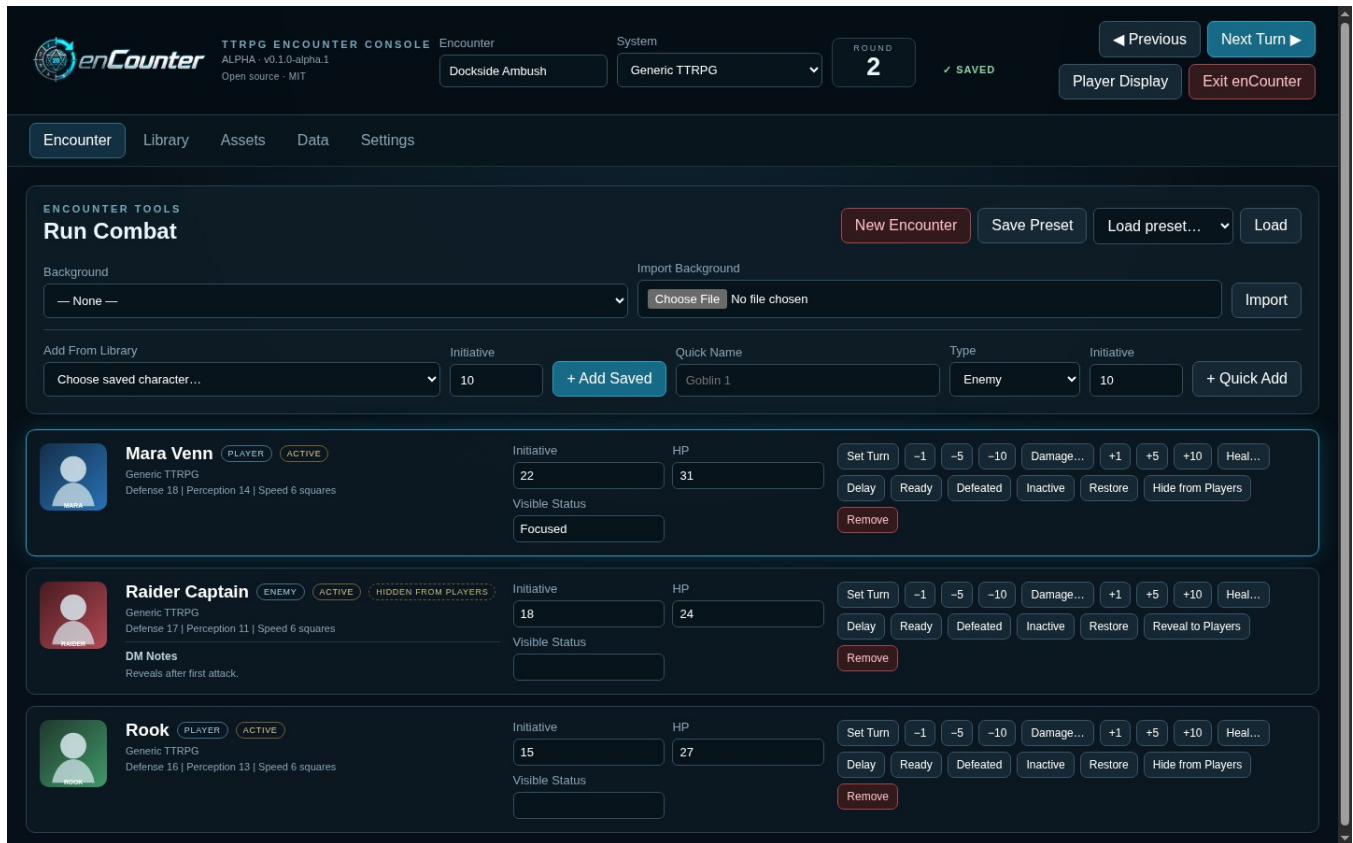


Figure 2 - DM Console Encounter screen with sample combatants.

4.1 Header controls

Control	Purpose
Encounter	Names the active encounter. Changes are saved when the field changes.
System	Selects Generic TTRPG, Star Wars Saga Edition, D&D 5E, or Custom.
ROUND	Shows the current round. enCounter updates it as initiative wraps.
SAVED / SAVING	Shows whether a browser save is currently in progress.
Previous / Next Turn	Moves backward or forward through eligible initiative combatants.
Player Display	Opens the separate player-facing display.
Exit enCounter	Attempts a final external backup, then stops the local server.

4.2 Main navigation

- Encounter - build and run the current encounter.
- Library - create and manage permanent reusable combatants.
- Assets - import and review portraits, backgrounds, tokens, and supported icons.
- Data - export, import, restore, request persistent storage, and restore recovery snapshots.
- Settings - select a tracker mode, enable modules, control automatic external backups, and define a custom ruleset.

5. Settings and First-Time Configuration

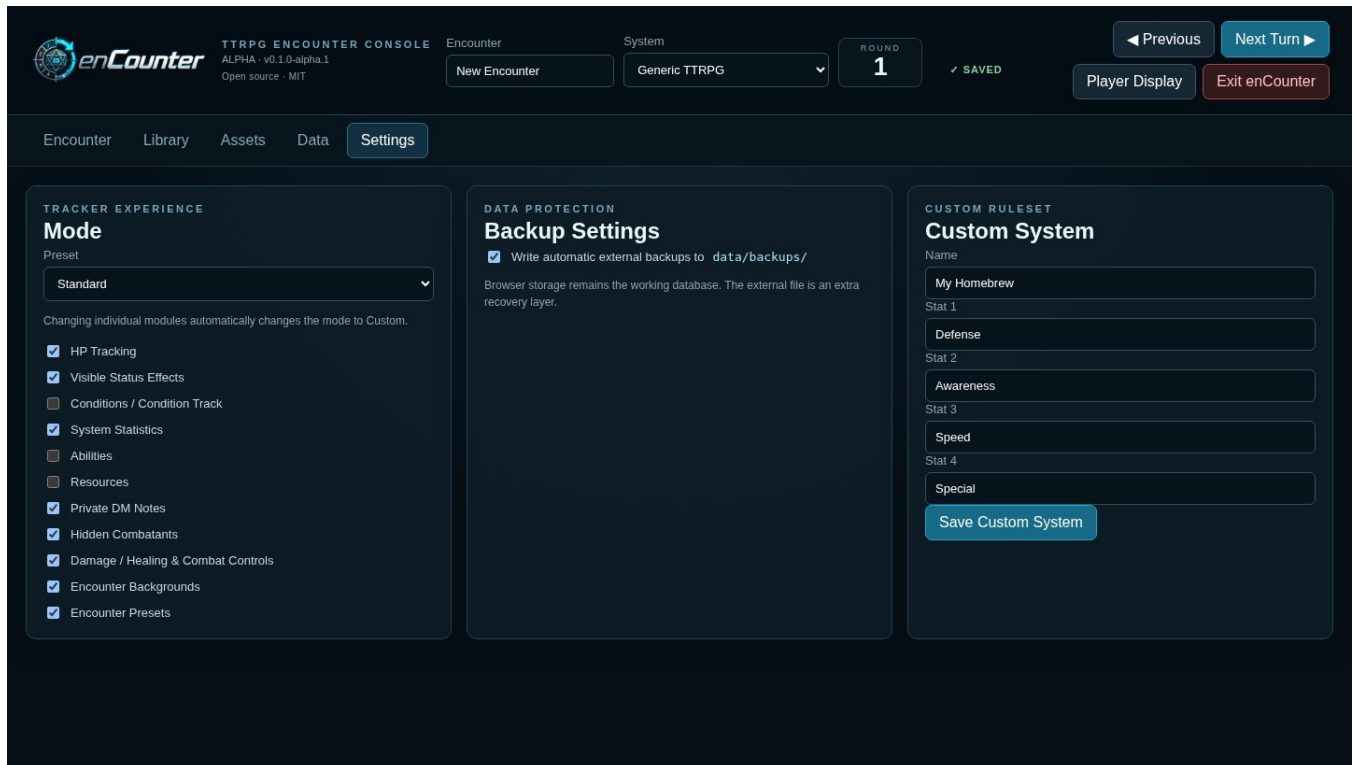


Figure 3 - Settings screen showing modes, automatic backup, and a Custom system.

5.1 Tracker modes

Modes control which combat-management modules are visible. Changing an individual module automatically changes the mode to Custom.

Mode	Best for	Default behavior
Simple	Initiative-only play	Backgrounds only; hides HP, statuses, stats, combat controls, notes, hidden-combatant controls, abilities/resources, and presets.

Mode	Best for	Default behavior
Standard	Typical encounter tracking	HP, visible status, system stats, DM notes, hidden combatants, damage/healing controls, backgrounds, and presets.
Advanced	Full feature set	Enables every available module, including conditions, abilities, and resources.
Custom	Tailored setup	Uses the exact module checkboxes you choose.

5.2 Automatic external backups

When Write automatic external backups is enabled, important saves schedule a JSON backup to data/backups/ in the portable enCounter folder. Browser IndexedDB remains the primary working database; the disk backup is an additional recovery layer.

5.3 Custom System

1. Choose Settings.
2. Enter a custom system Name.
3. Define labels for Stat 1 through Stat 4.
4. Click Save Custom System.
5. When creating Library entries or encounters, choose Custom as the system.

TIP: Configure the Custom system before creating many Custom-system Library entries so the saved labels are consistent.

6. Creating and Managing the Library

The Library is permanent reusable data. Adding a Library entry to an encounter creates a temporary encounter copy, so damage, initiative changes, statuses, and resource use during combat do not alter the permanent Library record.

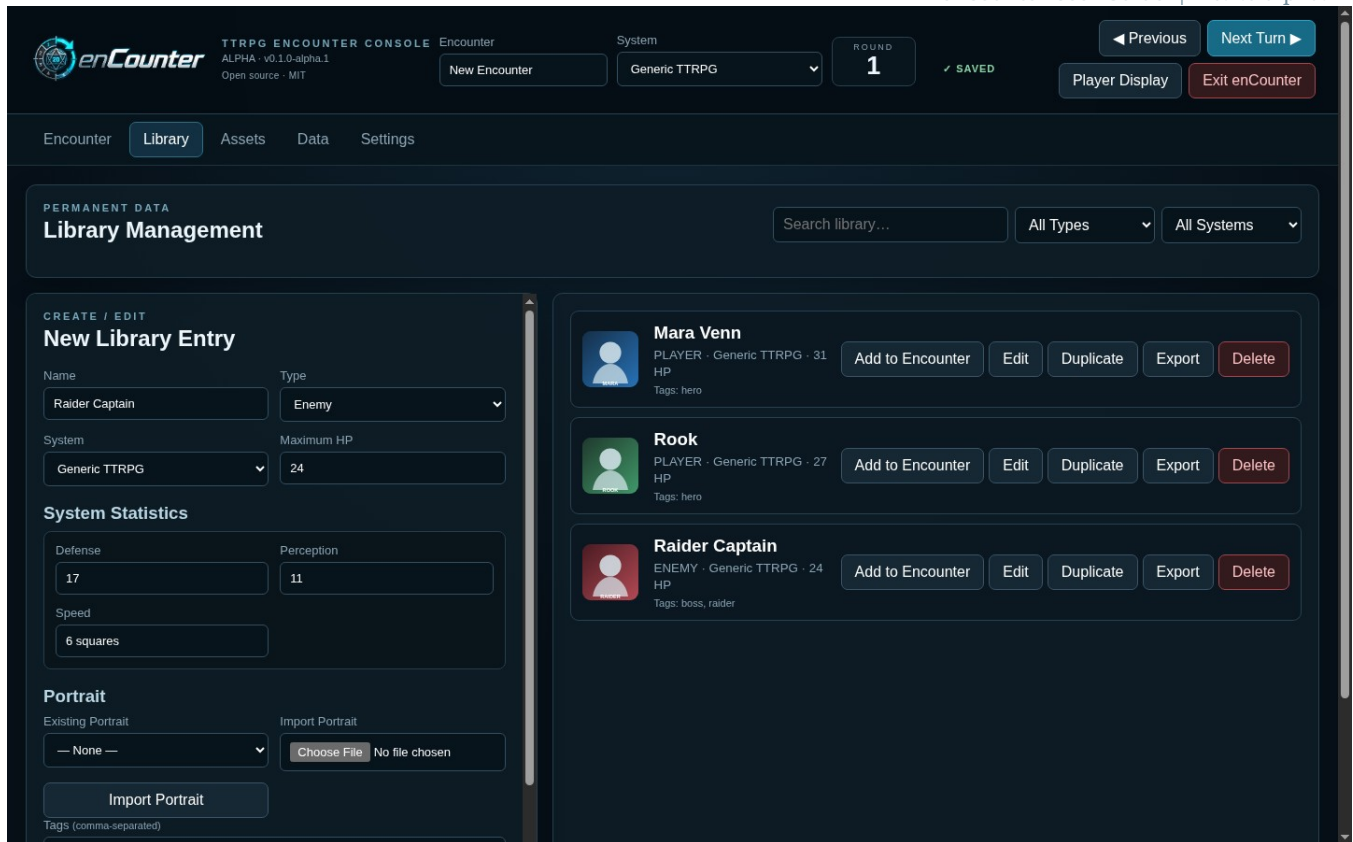


Figure 4 - Library Management with sample Players and an Enemy.

6.1 Create a Library entry

1. Open Library.
2. Enter the Name.
3. Choose Type: Player, NPC, Enemy, or Creature.
4. Choose the System. The System Statistics fields update to match the selected system.
5. Enter Maximum HP if HP tracking will be used.
6. Complete any displayed System Statistics.
7. Choose an existing Portrait or use Import Portrait to add a PNG, JPEG, or WebP image.
8. Optionally enter Tags separated by commas. Tags are searchable.
9. Optionally enter Private DM Notes. These are never shown on the Player Display.
10. If Abilities are used, enter one per line in the format Name | Uses | Description. Leave Uses blank for an unlimited ability.
11. If Resources are used, enter one per line in the format Name | Current | Max.
12. Click Save Library Entry.

Examples for structured fields

Ability example: Battle Cry | 1 | Grant nearby allies a temporary bonus

Resource example: Charges | 3 | 3

NOTE: Abilities and Resources are stored even when the current display mode does not show those modules. Switch to Advanced or enable the modules in Custom mode to use them during combat.

6.2 Search and filter

Use Search library to search names, tags, and private notes. Use the Type and System filters to narrow the visible Library cards.

6.3 Library card actions

Action	Result
Add	Prompts for initiative, adds a temporary copy to the current encounter, and returns to Encounter.
Edit	Loads the permanent entry into the editor.
Duplicate	Creates a new permanent copy named "<name> Copy."
Export	Downloads a JSON file containing only that one Library entry.
Delete	Permanently deletes the Library entry after confirmation. Existing encounter copies are not the permanent Library record.

7. Managing Portraits, Backgrounds, and Assets

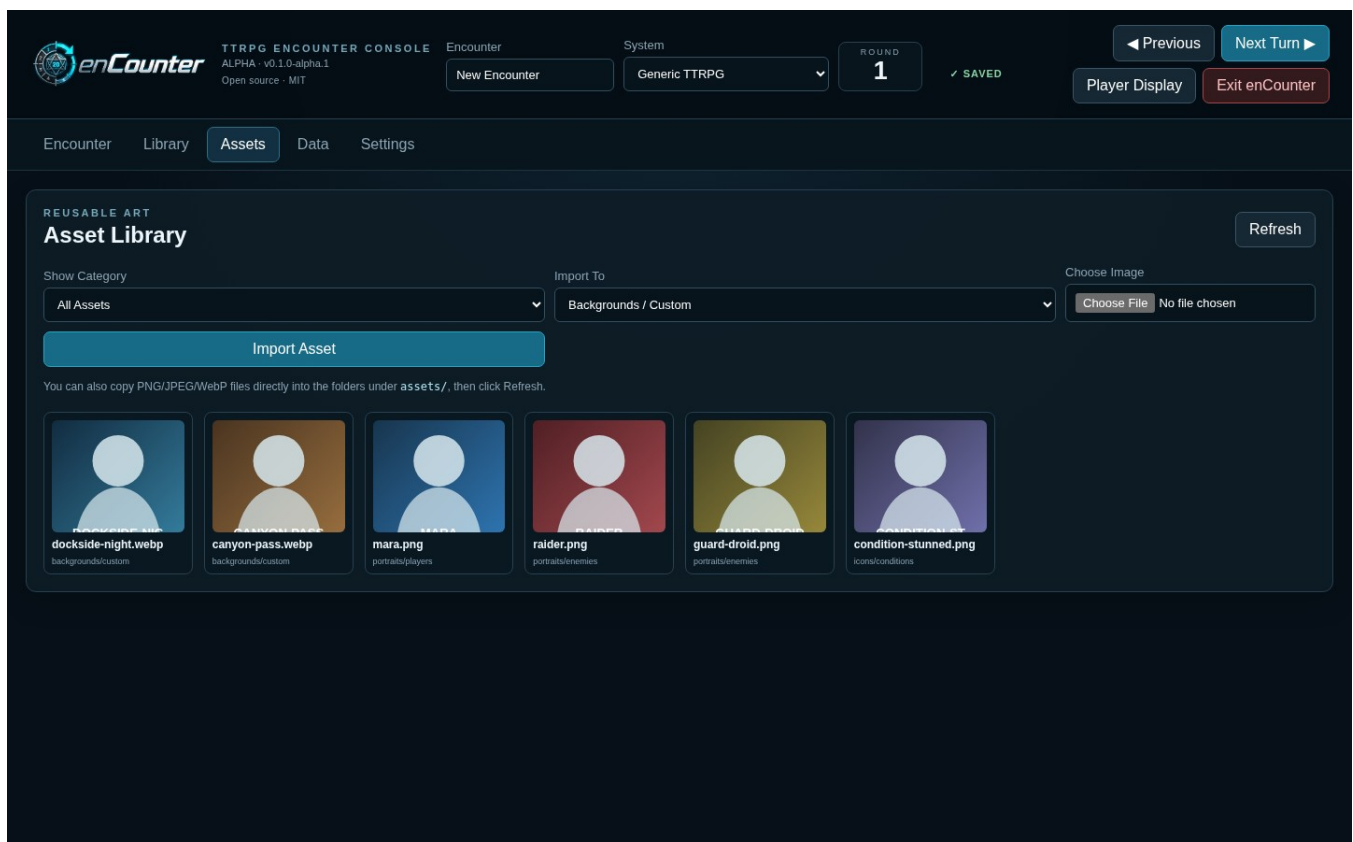


Figure 5 - Asset Library with sample reusable art.

7.1 Supported image files

- PNG
- JPEG / JPG
- WebP
- Maximum upload size: 10 MB per image

7.2 Import from the Assets screen

1. Open Assets.
2. Choose the destination category under Import To.
3. Choose an image file.
4. Click Import Asset.
5. Use Show Category to filter the grid if needed.

7.3 Copy files directly into the portable folder

You can also copy supported image files into the appropriate subfolder under assets/ while enCounter is not writing that file. Return to Assets and click Refresh so the application rescans the folders.

7.4 Portraits

The Library editor can import a portrait directly. enCounter chooses a portrait folder based on the Library type: Players, NPCs, Enemies, or Custom.

7.5 Encounter backgrounds

On the Encounter screen, choose a saved Background from the list or use Import Background. Backgrounds are shown behind the Player Display and remain part of the encounter configuration.

8. Creating an Encounter

8.1 Name and system

1. Open Encounter.
2. Enter a descriptive encounter name.
3. Choose the encounter System before adding combatants whenever possible.
4. Optionally select or import a background.

IMPORTANT: The Add From Library list only shows Library entries whose system matches the active encounter system. Changing the encounter system later does not automatically convert existing combatants to a new system profile.

8.2 Add a saved Library combatant

1. Choose a character from Add From Library.

2. Enter the initiative value.
3. Click + Add Saved.
4. The combatant is copied into the encounter. Changes made during combat do not change the permanent Library entry.

8.3 Quick Add

1. Enter a Quick Name.
2. Choose the Type.
3. Enter initiative.
4. Click + Quick Add.

Quick Add creates only an encounter combatant. It does not add a permanent Library entry.

8.4 Encounter presets

Presets are reusable encounter templates. They are useful for recurring enemy groups, standard patrols, or frequently used scenarios.

1. Build the encounter roster and optional background.
2. Click Save Preset and enter a preset name.
3. Later choose the preset from Load preset and click Load.
4. Confirm that the current encounter may be replaced.

NOTE: When a preset is saved or loaded for a new fight, transient combat values are reset: initiative returns to 10, HP returns to maximum when available, visible status/condition state is cleared, combatants become active, and hidden/delayed/readied flags are reset.

8.5 New Encounter

Click New Encounter to clear the active combat roster. A meaningful previous encounter is stored as a recovery snapshot first. The permanent Library, assets, presets, settings, and snapshots remain available.

9. Running Combat

9.1 Initiative and turns

Combatants are automatically sorted by initiative from highest to lowest. The current combatant receives a highlighted card.

- Next Turn advances to the next eligible combatant.
- Previous moves backward through eligible initiative.
- Round increases when moving forward wraps from the bottom of the eligible order back to the top.
- Round never goes below 1 when moving backward.
- Defeated, Inactive, Delayed, and Readied combatants are skipped by normal initiative advancement.
- Set Turn can make a combatant active and immediately set that combatant as the current turn.

9.2 Edit initiative, HP, and visible status

Edit Initiative directly on a combatant card; enCounter re-sorts the cards. When HP tracking is enabled, the HP field can be edited directly. When Visible Status Effects is enabled, comma-separated statuses are shown as badges on the Player Display.

9.3 Damage and healing

When combat controls and HP are enabled, use the -1, -5, -10 and +1, +5, +10 buttons for common adjustments. Damage... and Heal... prompt for a custom amount. Healing is capped at Maximum HP when a maximum is defined, and HP cannot fall below 0.

9.4 Condition Track

When the Conditions module is enabled and the combatant uses Star Wars Saga Edition, a Condition Track selector is available: Normal, -1, -2, -5, -10, or Helpless. Non-Normal values appear on the Player Display as a CT badge.

9.5 Delay, Ready, Defeated, Inactive, and Restore

Control	Effect
Delay	Marks the combatant Delayed and removes it from normal initiative advancement.
Ready	Marks the combatant Readied and removes it from normal initiative advancement.
Trigger / Resume	Returns a Delayed or Readied combatant to Active and sets it as the current turn.
Defeated	Marks the combatant Defeated. The Player Display dims it and labels it defeated.
Inactive	Marks the combatant Inactive. It remains visible but is skipped by normal initiative.
Restore	Returns a non-active combatant to Active without necessarily taking the turn immediately.
Remove	Removes the temporary combatant from the encounter only; the permanent Library entry is not deleted.

10. Hiding and Revealing Combatants

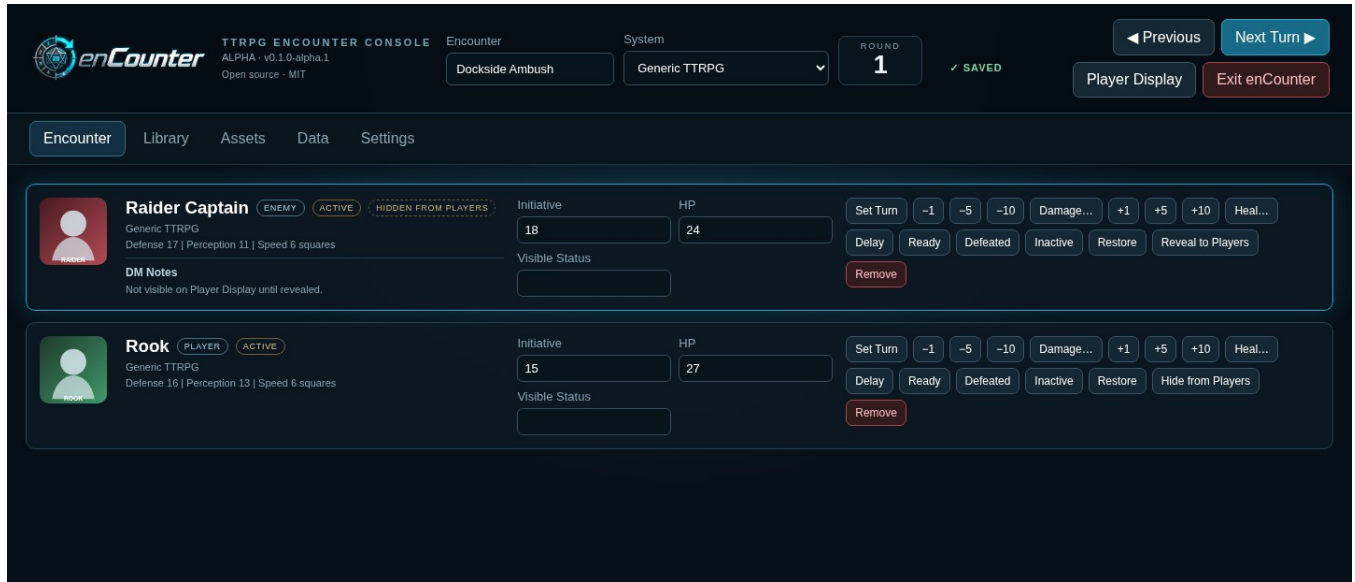


Figure 6 - A hidden enemy remains visible to the DM and is marked *Hidden from Players*.

When Hidden Combatants is enabled, each DM combatant card has Hide from Players / Reveal to Players.

1. Click Hide from Players before the combatant should be known to the players.
2. The DM card remains fully visible and gains a Hidden from Players badge.
3. The hidden combatant is completely omitted from the Player Display: no card, name, portrait, current-turn name, or next-turn name is shown.
4. When the enemy or NPC becomes known, click Reveal to Players. The card immediately reappears in its normal initiative position.

TIP: This is useful for ambushes, invisible enemies, secret reinforcements, and creatures that have not yet entered the scene.

11. Using the Player Display

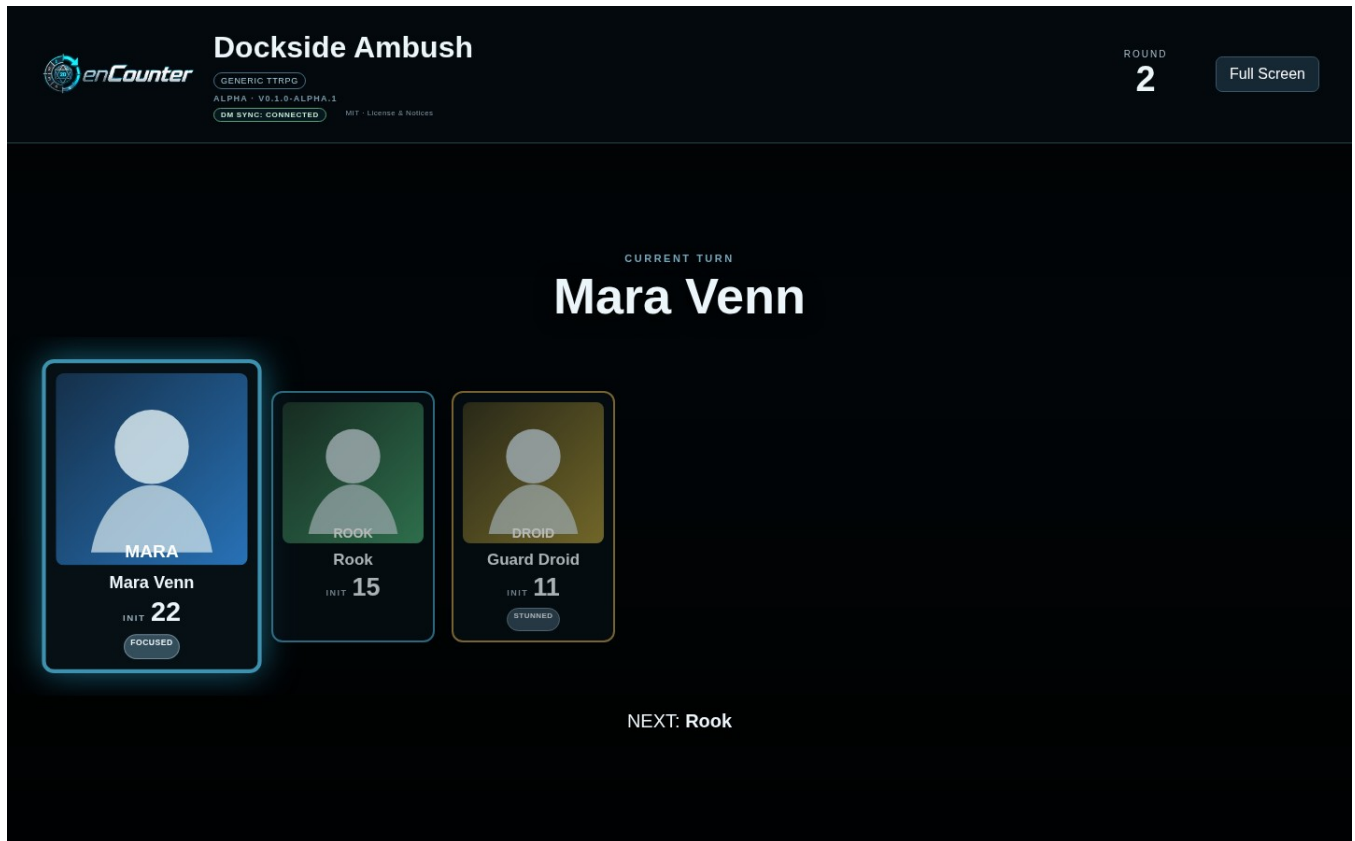


Figure 7 - Player Display with DM Sync connected. The hidden Raider Captain is omitted.

11.1 Open the display

1. Keep the DM Console open.
2. Click Player Display in the DM header.
3. A separate browser window opens.
4. Confirm the DM SYNC indicator becomes CONNECTED.
5. Move the Player Display window to the monitor or TV used by the players.
6. Click Full Screen on the Player Display when desired.

11.2 Same-browser-profile requirement

Player Display synchronization uses BroadcastChannel with a localStorage fallback. The DM Console and Player Display must be in the same browser profile. The normal Player Display button satisfies this requirement because it opens the display from the DM page.

CAUTION: Opening the Player Display in a different browser, a different browser profile, or a private/incognito session will not share the local synchronization channel. The display will show DM SYNC: DISCONNECTED rather than silently appearing connected.

11.3 What players see

- Encounter name and system
- Round number
- Current visible eligible combatant
- Visible initiative cards sorted by initiative
- Next visible eligible combatant
- Portraits
- Visible status badges
- Star Wars Saga Edition condition-track badge when applicable
- Defeated, Inactive, Delayed, and Readied state badges
- Encounter background

Private DM notes, damage/healing buttons, resource controls, hidden combatants, and other DM management controls are not shown.

11.4 Second monitor or TV - Windows

1. Connect the monitor or TV.
2. Press Windows + P and choose Extend rather than Duplicate.
3. Open Player Display from enCounter.
4. Drag the Player Display window onto the second screen.
5. Use Full Screen.

11.5 Second monitor - Linux

Use your desktop environment display settings to extend the desktop, then move the Player Display window onto the second display and use Full Screen.

12. Backups, Exports, Imports, and Recovery

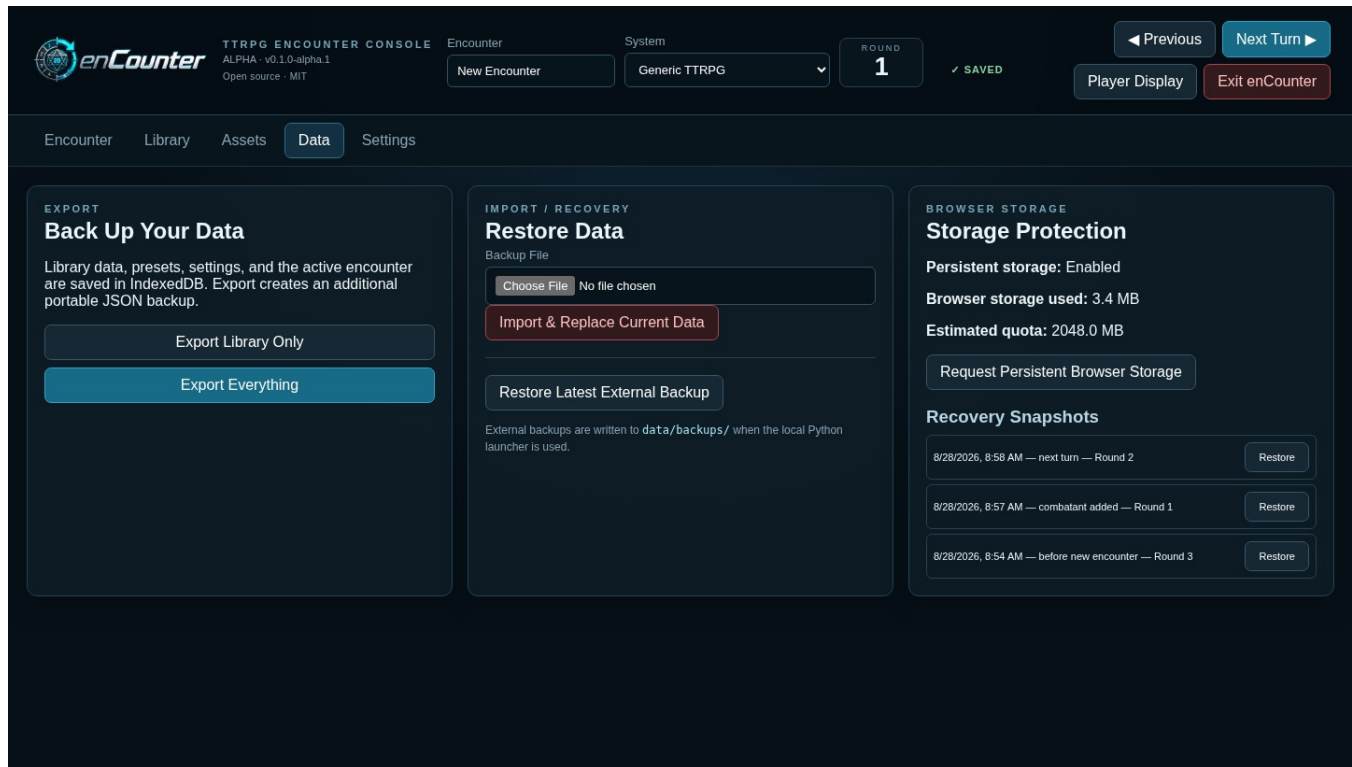


Figure 8 - Data screen for export, import, external backup recovery, and browser storage.

12.1 Understand the storage layers

Layer	What it contains	Where it lives
Browser working database	Library, active encounter, presets, settings, snapshots, metadata	IndexedDB in the browser profile (enCounterAlphaDB)
Automatic external backup	Library, encounters/presets, settings, metadata; does not include browser recovery snapshots	data/backups/ inside the portable enCounter folder
Manual Export Everything	Portable full JSON backup including browser recovery snapshots	Your browser Downloads folder unless you choose another download location
Manual Export Library Only	Permanent Library records only	Your browser Downloads folder

12.2 Automatic external backup

With automatic external backups enabled, enCounter writes data/backups/backup-latest.json after scheduled saves. Approximately once per hour, it can also create a timestamped backup-YYYYMMDD-HHMMSSZ.json history file. The launcher keeps up to 20 of these hourly history files.

IMPORTANT: Automatic external backup is an additional recovery layer, not the working database. Do not rely on only one copy of important campaign data.

12.3 Export Library Only

1. Open Data.
2. Click Export Library Only.
3. The browser downloads a file similar to enCounter-Library-2026-08-28.json.
4. Store the file somewhere safe or copy it with your campaign backups.

Importing a Library-only export through the Data screen replaces the current permanent Library but does not replace the active encounter, presets, or settings.

12.4 Export Everything

1. Open Data.
2. Click Export Everything.
3. The browser downloads a file similar to enCounter-Backup-2026-08-28.json.
4. Use this option before changing computers, testing a new Alpha version, or making a major campaign change.

Export Everything includes the Library, encounters, encounter presets, settings, metadata, and browser recovery snapshots.

12.5 Export a single Library entry

On a Library card, click Export to download only that one entry. A single-entry JSON can be imported later without clearing the rest of the Library.

12.6 Import and Replace Current Data

1. Open Data.
2. Choose the desired JSON file under Backup File.
3. Click Import & Replace Current Data.
4. Read the confirmation message carefully and continue only if the selected file is correct.
5. After import, enCounter reloads settings, Library data, the active encounter, assets, snapshots, and storage status.

CAUTION: A full backup import replaces the current application data. A Library-only import replaces the current Library. A single-entry export adds or updates only that one entry. Export the current state first if you might need to undo the import.

12.7 Restore Latest External Backup

Restore Latest External Backup reads data/backups/backup-latest.json and replaces the current browser data with that disk backup. Because automatic external backups intentionally omit browser recovery snapshots, restoring one may clear the current browser snapshot history.

12.8 Recovery snapshots

enCounter creates browser recovery snapshots at key encounter transitions, such as adding/removing combatants, changing combat states, moving turns, loading presets, changing systems, or starting a new encounter. The Data screen lists available snapshots with a Restore button.

1. Open Data.
2. Find the desired snapshot by date/time, reason, and round.
3. Click Restore.
4. Confirm the restore.
5. The snapshot replaces the active encounter only; the permanent Library is not changed.

12.9 Request Persistent Browser Storage

Click Request Persistent Browser Storage to ask the browser to protect enCounter storage from routine eviction. The browser decides whether to grant the request. This is useful but does not replace manual exports or disk backups.

13. Moving enCounter to Another Computer or USB

enCounter is portable, but its browser IndexedDB does not automatically travel with the application folder. Physical assets and JSON backup files do travel when you copy the folder.

13.1 Recommended transfer procedure

1. On the original computer, open Data and click Export Everything.
2. Copy the exported JSON into a safe location. You may place a copy under data/exports/ if you want it to travel with the portable folder.
3. Use Exit enCounter so the local process releases the folder.
4. Copy the entire enCounter portable folder to the USB drive or destination computer.
5. On the new computer, run enCounter from the copied folder.
6. Open Data, select the Export Everything JSON, and use Import & Replace Current Data.
7. Confirm portraits/backgrounds are available; these physical files should already have traveled with assets/.

TIP: Running from a USB drive is possible, but copying the folder to the local computer first is generally safer and faster. Avoid disconnecting removable storage while enCounter is writing an asset or backup.

14. Exiting enCounter Correctly

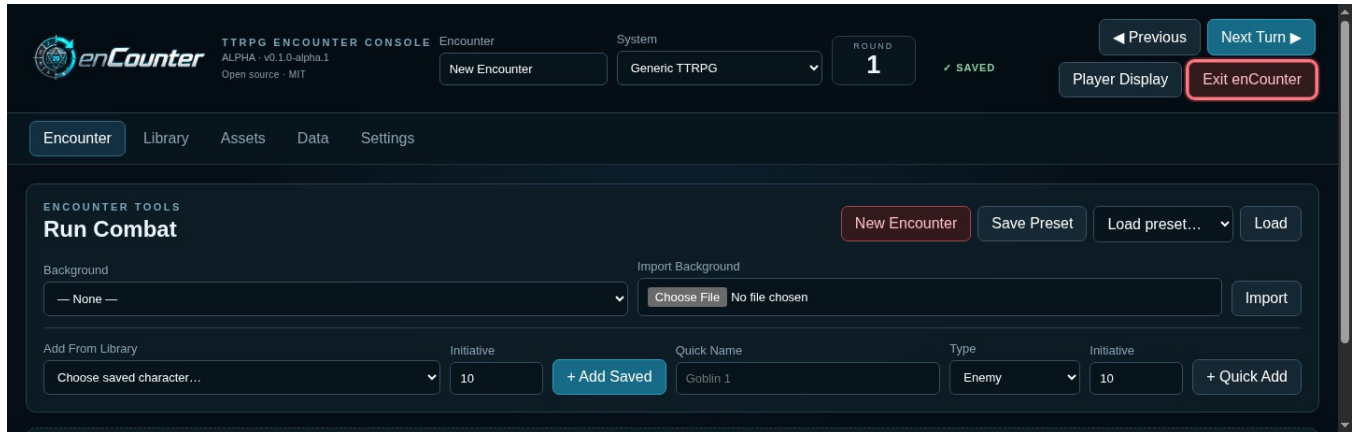


Figure 9 - Exit enCounter stops the local background server; closing only the browser may not.

Closing the browser tab does not necessarily stop enCounter.exe or the Linux enCounter process. The browser is only the interface; the local server can continue running in the background and may keep the application folder in use.

1. Finish the current action and wait until the header shows ✓ SAVED.
2. Click Exit enCounter in the DM Console.
3. Confirm the exit prompt.
4. If automatic external backups are enabled, enCounter attempts one final external backup.
5. The app sends a shutdown request to the local server and displays a stopped message.
6. Close the browser tab/window after the shutdown completes.

IMPORTANT: Always use Exit enCounter before deleting, replacing, renaming, or moving the application folder.

15. Recommended Game-Session Workflow

1. Start enCounter and resume the prior encounter only if it is still needed.
2. Open Settings and confirm the intended mode/modules.
3. Open Library and verify recurring PCs/NPCs/enemies are available.
4. Create or select an encounter background if desired.
5. Set the encounter name and system.
6. Add saved combatants and Quick Add any temporary combatants.
7. Hide unrevealed enemies before opening the Player Display.
8. Open Player Display, move it to the player monitor/TV, and verify DM SYNC: CONNECTED.
9. Run initiative with Previous/Next Turn and combatant controls.
10. Reveal hidden combatants when appropriate.
11. Use Data → Export Everything at important campaign milestones or before upgrading enCounter.

12. At the end of the session, wait for ✓ SAVED and click Exit enCounter.

16. Troubleshooting

16.1 Windows says the enCounter folder is in use

The local enCounter process may still be running because the browser was closed without using Exit enCounter.

1. Close any VS Code or File Explorer window that is actively using the old folder.
2. Open Task Manager with Ctrl + Shift + Esc.
3. Look for enCounter.exe. Older development copies may instead show python.exe or pythonw.exe.
4. End only the stale enCounter process associated with the old copy.
5. Try deleting or renaming the folder again.

16.2 enCounter cannot start because port 5500 is in use

Another enCounter instance or development server may still be listening on port 5500. Close the old instance using Exit enCounter or end the stale process, then start enCounter again.

16.3 Player Display says DISCONNECTED

- Open the Player Display using the button in the DM Console.
- Keep DM and Player Display in the same browser profile.
- Do not use one browser for the DM and another browser for the Player Display.
- Do not use a private/incognito Player Display when the DM uses the normal browser profile.
- Keep the DM Console open.

16.4 A Library entry does not appear under Add From Library

The encounter and Library entry systems must match. Check the active System in the DM header and the saved System on the Library entry.

16.5 Assets are not listed

- Confirm the file is PNG, JPEG/JPG, or WebP.
- Confirm the file is in a supported subfolder under assets/.
- Click Assets → Refresh after copying files manually.
- If importing through the UI, keep images at 10 MB or less.

16.6 Data appears missing on another computer

Browser IndexedDB is local to the browser profile and does not move just because the enCounter folder was copied. Restore an Export Everything backup on the new computer.

16.7 Restore or import reports an incompatible backup

A backup created by a newer database schema cannot be imported by an older enCounter build. Update enCounter to a compatible/newer version, then retry the import.

16.8 Linux reports permission denied

Run `chmod +x enCounter` in a terminal, then start it with `./enCounter`.

Appendix A - Mode and Module Reference

Module	Simple	Standard	Advanced
HP Tracking	Off	On	On
Visible Status Effects	Off	On	On
Conditions / Condition Track	Off	Off	On
System Statistics	Off	On	On
Abilities	Off	Off	On
Resources	Off	Off	On
Private DM Notes	Off	On	On
Hidden Combatants	Off	On	On
Damage / Healing & Combat Controls	Off	On	On
Encounter Backgrounds	On	On	On
Encounter Presets	Off	On	On

Custom mode is created automatically when you change individual module checkboxes and can contain any combination of the modules above.

Appendix B - Data and File Reference

Item	Typical location / filename	Purpose
Working browser DB	IndexedDB: enCounterAlphaDB	Primary active working data
Latest automatic backup	data/backups/backup-latest.json	Most recent automatic disk backup
Hourly backup history	data/backups/backup-YYYYMMDD-HHMMSSZ.json	Rotating external history, up to 20 files
Full manual export	enCounter-Backup-YYYY-MM-DD.json	Portable backup including browser snapshots
Library manual export	enCounter-Library-YYYY-MM-DD.json	Portable permanent Library only
Single Library export	<entry-name>.json	One reusable Library record
User backgrounds	assets/backgrounds/...	Player Display encounter backgrounds

Item	Typical location / filename	Purpose
User portraits	assets/portraits/...	Reusable character/enemy portraits

Appendix C - License, Privacy, and AI Disclosure

enCounter v0.1.0-alpha.1 is distributed under the MIT License. The application includes a legal/notices link in the DM Console and Player Display. The portable distribution also contains LICENSE and THIRD_PARTY_NOTICES.md.

enCounter is local-first. The Alpha server binds to 127.0.0.1 and is designed to keep encounter, Library, and campaign data on the local computer unless the user deliberately copies or shares an export or asset.

The project includes an AI_ASSISTANCE.md disclosure. Generative AI tools assisted with coding, debugging, documentation, project organization, testing suggestions, and release preparation. The current application does not itself contain generative-AI functionality and does not intentionally send campaign data to an AI service.

NOTE: Third-party game names, systems, products, companies, and trademarks remain the property of their respective owners. References in enCounter are for identification or compatibility and do not imply endorsement, sponsorship, or affiliation.

Quick Reference - End of Session

Before you close	Recommended action
1	Wait for ✓ SAVED.
2	Optionally use Data → Export Everything for a milestone backup.
3	Click Exit enCounter.
4	Wait for the stopped/shutdown confirmation.
5	Close the browser.
6	Only then move, replace, or delete the enCounter folder.